

Personal Statement 2

I am applying for the Four-Year PhD in Mental Health at UCL because I intend to develop my clinical research career at a world-leading research institution. I am applying specifically to this four-year programme because I am very keen to complete a Masters degree in addition to a PhD, as this will enable me to make a well-informed decision about my final PhD topic, and also make me a more rounded mental health researcher. I have the personal characteristics and research experience that will enable me to excel in this programme.

I have the academic ability to succeed in this PhD, as demonstrated by my First Class undergraduate degree. Specifically, I was also awarded a First Class grade for my final year BSc research project, recognising that I perform well when designing and carrying out my own research.

My valuable experience at the Universities of Reading and Birmingham has allowed me to demonstrate personal characteristics that make me well suited to a career in research. My coding and transcribing of hundreds of experiments shows I am patient and dedicated, necessary for lengthy data preparation. My work checking and editing data for a large clinical trial shows I am meticulous and observant, necessary to ensure a consistent and accurate dataset. My work running experiments with both children and adults shows I am friendly and professional while interacting with participants, essential for data collection. Finally, my recent work discussing and altering experimental designs shows I am creative and reflective, essential for developing new research ideas and directions.

My previous work experience also demonstrates that I will excel in mental health research in particular. My role as a trial therapist gave me first-hand clinical experience and enabled me to develop skills such as empathy, building rapport and client confidentiality, which are particularly important when conducting mental health research.

My specific research interest is in improving treatment for people experiencing mood disorders. I am particularly interested in three areas of this research: Firstly, I am interested in how depression and anxiety present in primary care, and how the understanding and response of GPs to these disorders might be improved. Secondly, I am interested in the early detection and treatment of mood disorders in childhood and adolescence. Thirdly, I am interested in how informal helping, such as family involvement or online support groups, can aid the recovery from anxiety and depression. I understand that the expertise of researchers at UCL would support these research interests.

A great many people are suffering from psychological disorders that are not yet fully understood, or for which efficient treatment has not yet been implemented. I am wholly motivated to be part of the research movement that is trying to understand these complexities, in order to ultimately improve outcomes for patients. I am creative, motivated and dedicated, with an outstanding academic record and relevant mental health research experience. This combination of characteristics makes me an excellent candidate to join UCL for this challenging and fascinating programme.